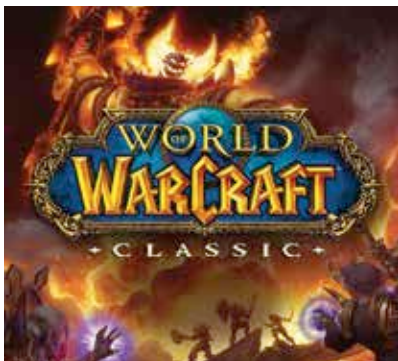


While power creep is present in video games, it's most rampant in CCG games, or collectible card games. Of course, this translates well with gacha games as well, or all those mobile games which are all about collecting characters; these are also victims of power creep. We'll get to CCG games specifically in a bit. But first, some solutions.

How to deal with power creep?

There are a few tricks devs have employed in order to deal with power creep. Continuing with WoW as an example, we've got the Heroic dungeons. This made old content, i.e., dungeons viable again and gave players a reason to experience old content again, and devs a reason to revisit old content and retune it to current standards. Additionally, in order to bring the overall power curve down, with the latest WoW expansion, Shadowlands, the level cap was dropped from 120 back to 60.



WoW Classic

Furthermore, WoW Classic was something a lot of players were excited about, because it would allow players to enjoy old content in the game, without any of the power creep from future expansions. Final Fantasy XIV uses something called Level Sync, which brings your characters' gear level and overall level down to the level of the dungeon, locking abilities that you shouldn't have access to. Players are incentivised to do old content with upscaled rewards. This way, newer players who have to play through old content constantly have experienced



Horizontal progression like in GW2 doesn't punish players for taking a break from the game



That's a lotta incomparables

players running old content to guide them. Guild Wars 2 automatically scales character levels down to whatever area they're currently in and rewards are always scaled to your level. Furthermore, the game uses something called Horizontal Progression; the game's level cap has been level 80 since day one despite four additional expansions. Gear you acquired for a level 80 character when the game first launched is still viable in the latest expansion. From a player point of view, you never have to worry about "being left behind" if you decide to take a break for a while.

Other than revisiting old content, another solution to power creep is using incomparables. Quite literally, like the name suggests, introducing incomparable content, or content that can't

be compared to existing content. Here, rather than introducing content that is simply better numbers, i.e., new sword deals 1 more damage than old sword, so ditch old sword, you might introduce a mace instead. It could be situationally stronger or weaker than the sword; deal more damage to heavy armor, but weak against leather where the sword might excel. This way you can't tell whether new content is better or not, instead it's situational, so old isn't useless but circumstantial. The more the number of incomparables in a pool, the more balance becomes subjective, and the more important actual player skill becomes.

However, incomparables take a lot more time and money to create, and like we just mentioned, they also make a game more skill heavy which isn't always beneficial.